

1. Subjective Relativism

Subjective relativism is the idea that every person decides for themselves what is right and wrong. There are no universal moral rules that apply to everyone. This theory is helpful because it explains why different people can have completely different opinions on moral issues based on their own values and experiences. However, a major problem is that it makes it hard to tell the difference between doing what someone thinks is right and just doing whatever they want. It also doesn't give us a logical way to say one person's judgment is better than another's, which is why the textbook doesn't consider it a workable theory. For example, one student might think sharing a textbook PDF is wrong, while another thinks it is fine. Under this theory, both would be considered right for that person.

2. Cultural Relativism

Cultural relativism says that each society decides its own moral guidelines. This means an action can be right in one culture but wrong in another because different groups have different standards. This theory is useful for understanding and comparing other cultures without judging them based on our own standards. The biggest limitation is that it makes it hard to criticize harmful practices in other societies, and it doesn't help when different groups within the same society disagree. The textbook points out that just because a culture has different standards doesn't mean all standards are equally good. An example would be how different cultures have different expectations for family responsibilities or social behavior.

3. Divine Command Theory

Divine command theory states that an action is right if it follows God's commands and wrong if it violates them. This means moral rules come from a divine authority rather than human reasoning. This theory works well for people whose religious beliefs are the foundation of their moral decisions, as it provides clear guidance. However, a limitation is that there are many different religions and holy books with different teachings, and even people within the same religion interpret things differently. It is hard to use this theory to persuade someone who does not share the same religious beliefs. For example, someone whose religion teaches that stealing is wrong may choose not to steal because it violates God's commands.

4. Ethical Egoism

Ethical egoism says that a person should choose the action that gives them the most long-term benefit. The focus is entirely on the decision-maker's own self-interest. This theory can be used when looking at how choices affect your own long-term goals, like education, money, or health. The problem is that people often have short-term desires that conflict with their long-term interests, and more importantly, this theory ignores the interests of other people. An example would be a student choosing to study instead of going to a party because getting a good grade will benefit them more in the long run.

5. Kantianism

Kantianism evaluates actions based on moral duties and principles. One of its main ideas is the Categorical Imperative, which asks if a rule could be followed by everyone. It also says we must treat people as ends in themselves, not just as tools to get what we want. This theory is useful when an ethical problem involves duties, honesty, promises, or rights. A limitation is that following a strict rule can sometimes lead to bad consequences in a specific situation, and it focuses more on duties than on results. For example, if someone wants to steal, Kantian reasoning would ask if everyone could follow the rule "steal whenever you want something." If everyone did that, the idea of property would fall apart.

6. Act Utilitarianism

Act utilitarianism looks at each individual action and judges it by its consequences. The right action is the one that produces the greatest overall benefit for everyone affected. This theory is useful when you have several options and can compare the consequences of each one. The problem is that it is very hard to predict all the consequences of an action and figure out how much happiness or harm it creates. It can also lead to situations where a small group is sacrificed for the greater good of a larger group. For example, if a university has limited funding, act utilitarianism would compare the benefits of two programs and choose the one that helps the most people overall.

7. Rule Utilitarianism

Rule utilitarianism focuses on rules rather than individual actions. It says a rule is morally correct if following it generally would produce the greatest overall benefit for society. This theory is useful when creating rules that apply to many people. Instead of just asking if one action has good results, we ask what would happen if everyone followed the rule. A limitation is that a general rule can sometimes produce a bad result in a rare, specific situation, and it still faces the general problems of predicting consequences. An example would be the rule "do not copy copyrighted material without permission." If everyone followed this rule, it would help maintain incentives for authors and publishers to keep creating educational materials.

8. Social Contract Theory

Social contract theory says that morality consists of rules that rational people would agree to follow for mutual benefit, as long as everyone else follows them too. It is closely tied to rights, duties, fairness, and cooperation in society. The textbook also discusses John Rawls's idea that social and economic inequalities should benefit the least-advantaged people. This theory is useful for examining laws, rights, and responsibilities. However, a limitation is that none of us literally signed a contract, and it is hard to resolve situations where two people's rights conflict. Copyright laws can be viewed through this theory by asking if rational people would agree to protect creators' rights in exchange for a system that supports the creation of information.

9. Virtue Ethics

Virtue ethics focuses on the character of the person making the decision, rather than just the action or its consequences. A virtuous person develops good character traits and tries to act like a good person would. This theory is useful when thinking about character, habits, responsibility, and what a morally good person would do. The textbook explains that it considers things like moral education, relationships, and emotions. A limitation is that people disagree on which traits are virtues and what a flourishing life looks like, so it gives less specific guidance than other theories. For example, if a student gets extra money by mistake from the university, a person using virtue ethics might return it because honesty and integrity are traits of a virtuous person.

References

Quinn, M. J. (2025). *Ethics for the information age* (9th ed.). Pearson